Civil Twilight

By Chuck Palahniuk

It was the summer people quit complaining about the price of gasoline.

On June 24, sunset was at 8:35. Civil twilight ended at 9:07. A woman, walking uphill on the steep stretch of Lewis Street, heard a pounding sound. It was the sound a pile driver might make, a heavy stomping sound every few seconds, getting louder with each stomp, getting closer. Somewhere in the dark between streetlights, something glass broke. A newspaper box blew over sideways, crashing into the street. The crash came again and the windows blew out of a glass telephone booth only three parked cars away from where she stood and then the lights went out.

The street was dark. A mailbox, bolted to the curb, it boomed loud as a cannon, then stood shaking, vibrating, dented and leaning to one side. A wooden utility pole shuddered, the cables draped across it

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rattling against each other, the sparks sprinkling down, bright summer fireworks. Then nothing. Nothing happened. Nothing had gone by in the dark street.

INTRODUCTION

Those who study our enduring fascination with monsters often point out several reasons for the lure of such fantastic beings.

Monsters represent the ultimate "other." They're a safe way to pretend that evil is less human than it usually is . . . they reinforce the comforting fantasy that you can instantly tell who's good and who's bad. In real life, of course, it's hardly ever that simple.

And although adults may no longer be afraid of the dark, they are, and should be, afraid of the monsters that often inhabit it . . . Chuck Palahniuk extends the darkness to a period called "civil twilight." Civil twilight is the period of time between sunset and when the sun is more than six degrees below the horizon. That six degrees equals about half an hour. And it is during this time that the adult monster of this story stalks his or her prey.

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On July 1, people were complaining about the water shortage. They were griping about city budget cuts and all the police getting laid off. Car prowls were on the rise. Spray-paint tagging and armed robbery.

On July 2, they weren't. On July 2, a woman walking her dog found the body of Lorenzo Curdy, the side of his face caved in. Dead. The moment before he was hit, the man must've felt something, maybe the rush of air, because he put his hands up in front of his face. When they found him, both hands were buried, punched so deep in his face his fingernails had dug into his own crushed brain.

On a street, the moment you're between streetlights, there in the dark you'd hear it. The stomp. You might hear a second sound from closer, somewhere nearby, or, worse, the next victim would be you. People heard it coming, once, twice, closer, and they froze. Or they forced their feet, left, right, left, three or four steps into a close-by doorway. They crouched, cowering next to parked cars. Closer, the next stomp came. It was coming down the street, sounding closer, getting

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loud and gaining speed. In the pitch-dark it would hit—bam—a bolt of black lightning.

On July 13, sunset at 8:33 with civil twilight over at 9:03, a woman named Angela Davis had just left work at a dry cleaner's on Center Street when nothing hit her square in the middle of her back, breaking her spine so hard it lifted her out of her shoes.

On July 17, when civil twilight ended at 9:01, a man named Glenn Jacobs stepped off a bus. What nobody saw, slammed into him so hard his ribcage collapsed. His chest punched in the way you'd crush a wicker basket.

July 25, civil twilight ended at 8:55. Mary Leah Stanek was last seen jogging along Union Street. She stopped to tie one tennis shoe and check her pulse against her wristwatch. Stanek pulled off the baseball cap she wore. She turned it backward and put it back on, tucking her long brown hair up under it. She headed west on Pacific Street, and then she was dead. Her face torn loose from the skull and muscle underneath.

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What killed Stanek, was wiped clean of fingerprints. Clotted with blood and hair. They found the murder weapon wedged under a parked car down along 2nd Avenue. It was a bowling ball, the police reported. Those smudged, greasy-black bowling balls, you can buy them at any thrift shop for half a buck.

The police held a press conference. They stood in a parking lot and someone threw a bowling ball down, threw it hard against the concrete. And the ball bounced. It made the sound of a pile driver far away. It bounced high, taller than the man who threw it. It didn't leave a mark, and if the sidewalk were sloped, the police said, it would keep going, bouncing higher, faster, bouncing downhill in long strides.

The city council pushed for a law to paint all balls bright pink. Or neon yellow, orange, or green, some color you could see flying at your face down a dark side street late at night. To give people just a moment to dodge before—blam—their face is gone. City fathers pushed for a law to make owning black balls a crime.

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The bowling ball was a police cover-up, people said. The bowling ball was a red herring. A monster wannabe. The bowling ball was a quick fix to keep everybody calm.

On July 31, the sun was six degrees under the horizon at 8:49. That night, Darryl Earl Fitzhugh was homeless, sleeping on Western Avenue when his chest was crushed, both his lungs collapsed, and his heart muscle ruptured.

According to one witness, the killer came out of the bay, dragging itself over the lip of the seawall. Another witness saw the monster, dripping ooze, squeezing up from the storm sewer. These same people said the forensic evidence was consistent with a hard backhanded slap from a giant lizard walking on its hind legs. The ribcage collapsed was sure proof the victim was stepped on by some dinosaur throwback. Something dashed past, other people said, something low to the ground, too fast to be an animal. Or it was a maniac run amok with a fifty-pound sledgehammer. One witness said we were being "smote" by God from the Old Testament.

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Everyone saw something different. . . . people need a monster they can believe in. A true and horrible enemy. A demon to define themselves against. Otherwise, it's just us versus us.

See . . . all day long our biggest enemy is other people. It's people packed around us in traffic. People ahead of us in line at the supermarket. It's the supermarket checkers who hate us for keeping them so busy. People didn't want this killer to be another human being. But they wanted people to die. What people wanted was a sacrifice every few days, something to throw in the volcano. Our regular offering to random fate.

Of course, there was a hero. By accident, August 2, sunset at 8:34, a twenty-seven-year-old named Maria Alvarez was leaving a hotel where she worked as the night auditor. She stood on the curb, stopped to light a cigarette when a man pulled her back. That same instant, the monster rushed past. This man had saved her life. The city applauded on television, but in their hearts, they hated him.

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What's important is, the crime rate went down. In times like that, every man is a suspect. Every woman, a potential victim.

Public attention went this same way during the White Chapel Murders of Jack the Ripper. For those hundred days, the murder rate dropped 94 percent. Burglaries dropped by 85 percent. Assault by 70 percent. Nobody wanted to be the next victim of the Ripper. People locked their windows. More important, nobody wanted to be accused of being the killer. People didn't walk out at night.

During the Atlanta Child Murders, while thirty kids were strangled, tied to trees, and stabbed, beaten, and shot, most of the city lived in security and safety they'd never known.

During the New Orleans Ax Man Murders, the killer wrote the local newspaper, theTimes-Picayune. On the night of March 19, the killer promised to kill no one in a house where he could hear jazz music. That night, New Orleans was roaring with music, and no one was killed.

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During these waves of murder, all crime dropped in each city. In a city with a limited police budget a high-profile serial killer is an effective means of behavior modification.

With the shadow of this horrible bogeyman, with it stalking the streets downtown, nobody beefed about the unemployment rate. The water shortage. The traffic. With the angel of death going door to door, people stayed together. They behaved.

How it ended is, one night the monster got a dog. A hairy rag of a little dog on the end of a leash, tied to a parking meter on Porter Street, it stood and barked as the pounding came closer. The closer the sound came, the more the dog barked. A store window webbed into a puzzle of broken glass. A fire hydrant clanked to one side, cracked cast iron, hissing a white curtain of water. The edge of a windowsill explodes in a spray of gravel and concrete dust. One more stomp and the barking stopped.

The monster seemed to disappear after that night. A week went by, and the streets were still empty

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after dark. A month went by, and the editors found some new horror to put on the front page of the newspaper. A war somewhere else. Some new kind of cancer.

On September 10, sunset was at 8:02. Curtis Hammond was leaving a group-therapy session he attended every week at 257 West Mill Street. He was pulling down the knot of his tie when it happened. He'd just opened his collar button. It was when he'd just turned to look up the street. He smiled at the warm air on his face, shut his eyes, and breathed in through his nose. A month before, everyone in town knew him from the front page of the paper. From the television news. He'd pulled a night auditor away from getting killed by the monster. From getting smote by God. He was the hero we didn't want.

On September 10, civil twilight was at 8:34, and a moment later, Curtis Hammond turned toward a noise. His tie loose, he squinted into the dark. Smiling, his teeth shining, he said, "Hello?"

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